

**A REVIEW OF THE GUIDELINES OF THE CODE OF ETHICS FOR
PHARMACEUTICAL INSPECTORS**

A Presentation by

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1.0 Introduction

In academic institutions, particularly at the tertiary level, certificates and degrees are awarded to graduates who are found worthy in both learning

and character. In line with this principle, the pharmacy profession operates under a Code of Professional Conduct, which regulates practitioners and outlines the principles governing their interactions with clients, other professionals, and the public (PCN, 2009).

As custodians of human life, pharmacists must uphold ethical standards to ensure protection and confidentiality. This is especially crucial for pharmaceutical inspectors, who are empowered by law to access premises at reasonable times as part of their statutory duties. Inspectors are therefore called to carry out their responsibilities within the confines of professional ethics. This paper provides guidance toward achieving improved, ethical, and effective inspection practices.

2.0 Conceptual Clarification

2.1 Code of Conduct

According to Rosenberg (2004), a Code of Conduct is a statement of ethical practices and guidelines to which an enterprise adheres. The Longman Active Study Dictionary defines it as rules that people in a particular business agree to obey. For pharmaceutical inspectors, this means maintaining the highest standards of professionalism, decorum, and etiquette, while being pharmacists of both qualification and character.

2.2 Ethics

Rosenberg (2004) defines ethics as personal beliefs about what is right or wrong. The Longman Active Study Dictionary describes ethics as a belief that influences people's behavior. For inspectors, ethics entails impartiality, transparency, and skillfulness during inspections.

The PCN Code of Ethics guides pharmacists in fulfilling their moral and professional obligations, ensuring conduct consistent with the dignity of the profession (PCN, 2009).

3.0 The Ethics of Pharmaceutical Inspection

No two inspections are identical, even within the same specialty. For instance, an inspection of a pharmaceutical manufacturing facility to assess

compliance with current Good Manufacturing Practice (cGMP) requires inspectors to exercise sound judgment to ensure product quality, safety, and efficacy.

Inspectors must never disclose information obtained in one facility to another. While questions are asked during inspections, truthful and transparent answers are expected. The fine line between honesty and concealment must always be carefully navigated.

The PCN ensures inspectors are competent before issuing them identity cards, with selection processes carried out by the Inspection and Monitoring (I&M) Department and the Pharmaceutical Inspection Committee (PIC). Only pharmacists with sound professional records and knowledge are recommended as inspectors.

Unfortunately, instances of unethical behavior by inspectors have been recorded in the past. Inspectors must recognize that their conduct reflects not just on themselves but also on the profession, stakeholders, and the PCN. Ethics extend beyond inspections—they must be evident in the inspector's professional and social life.

Furthermore, inspectors are required to continuously update their skills through the Mandatory Continuing Professional Development (MCPD) programme. Inspectors who fail to do so cannot adequately carry out their roles. Indeed, “a pharmaceutical inspector cannot give what he/she does not have.”

4.0 The Regulatory Responsibility of the PCN in Maintaining Ethics in Pharmaceutical Inspection

Pharmaceutical premises may be established for retail, wholesale, importation, hospital practice, or manufacturing. The PCN plays a vital role in registration, approval, licensing, and monitoring. The quality of inspections during registration often determines the level of professionalism practiced in such premises.

Monitoring exercises, conducted by PCN staff, complement the work of the PIC by ensuring Good Pharmacy Practice (GPP) across all categories of premises.

5.0 Conclusion, Recommendations, and Implementation Strategies

5.1 Conclusion

A PCN pharmaceutical inspector must uphold the highest ethical standards and decorum, both during inspections and in daily conduct. Their professional and social behavior must be exemplary, reflecting the integrity of the profession.

5.2 Recommendations

Recommendation 1

The Code of Ethics for PCN Pharmaceutical Inspectors should be reviewed periodically to reflect professional advancements and improve the credibility of inspections.

Implementation-Strategies:

- a) The PCN Law and Ethics Committee should periodically review the Code.
- b) All inspectors must be adequately informed of updates to the Code.

Recommendation 2

Inspectors should continually update their knowledge, skills, and competencies.

Implementation Strategies:

- a) Mandatory participation in the MCPD programme.
- b) Organization of periodic seminars, workshops, and conferences for inspectors.

Recommendation 3

Stakeholders should be enlightened on the identity and role of PCN inspectors to discourage impostors.

Implementation-Strategies:

- a) PCN should publish the list of inspectors periodically in major national dailies.
- b) The honorarium of inspectors should be reviewed upward to encourage and motivate them.

References

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Rosenberg, J. M. (2004). The Essential Dictionary of Management and Human Resources. Barnes and Noble Books.